evidence—two letters by VOC—indicate that the efforts had begun even earlier.

As already noted, VOC had given up his successful practice to take up the promotion of the Swadeshi shipping line. He had not ventured into new waters without preparation. On 23 March, he wrote from Tuticorin:

> I hope you will be very glad to know that we are making arrangements to get Sudeshi [*sic*] Steamers to ply between Tuticorin and Colombo. We have got an agreement executed by all the merchants of this place to Sena Vana & four others to abide by any conditions of any agreement that may have to be executed with the owner of the Sudeshi Steamers. I send herewith that agreement for your signature. I request you will be kindly pleased to sign it and give it to the bearer at once. I need not write to you much because you yourself have a very good great interest in the welfare of our motherland. Messrs Sena Kana & Ana Chana have already signed the agreement. Please advise our Ceylon friends & brethren to avoid foreign goods. Hoping this will find you in sound health.[25]

Though the identity of the addressee is not known, we can surmise that he was a Colombo-based merchant with Swadeshi leanings, and that the enterprise, from its inception, married Swadeshi ideology (‘the welfare of the motherland’) with business interests (‘avoid foreign goods’). Apparently, the core group led by ‘Sena Vana’ (S.V. Nallaperumal Pillai and/or his firm) and four other merchants had come together to ship all cargo from Tuticorin exclusively using their own ‘Sudeshi’ (the Tamil transliteration of ‘Swadeshi’) steamers.

On 12 April, VOC was writing to another trader. Though the name of the trader remains unknown, from the personal matters discussed in the letter, we can surmise he was a Parava merchant—most likely one M.N. Gonsalves who switched sides. In the intervening three weeks, VOC had made a trip to Colombo to mobilize the merchants—as we also saw from reports in the Ceylon newspapers.

> I thank you very much for the kindness shown to me while I had been to Colombo and for the earnest interest you take on behalf of the Swadeshi.
>
> One of the two steamers, *Shah Alam* and *Shah Amere*, which have been engaged for us have come here and the proprietor had wired to his Superintendent of Steamers to stay here till the reach of his detailed letter. The Superintendent is now here amidst us. The other Steamer, *Shah Alam*,[26] and the steam-launch are expected here on the 20th